

VARUN IYER

[408-781-1118](tel:408-781-1118) | varun@varuniyer.net | [LinkedIn](#) | [GitHub](#) | [Google Scholar](#)

EDUCATION

University of Illinois Chicago <i>Doctor of Philosophy in Computer Science</i>	Aug 2022 – Present
Johns Hopkins University <i>Master of Science in Engineering - Computer Science</i>	Aug 2020 – May 2022
University of Massachusetts Amherst <i>Bachelor of Science in Computer Science</i>	Aug 2017 – May 2020

PUBLICATIONS

* denotes equal contribution

1. **Varun Iyer** and Cornelia Caragea. BLoop: Zero-Shot Abstractive Summarization using Large Language Models with Bigram Lookahead Promotion. In *Proceedings of the Fifteenth Biennial Language Resources and Evaluation Conference (LREC)*, 2026.
2. Kuan-Hao Huang, **Varun Iyer**, I-Hung Hsu, Anoop Kumar, Kai-Wei Chang, and Aram Galstyan. ParaAMR: A Large-Scale Syntactically Diverse Paraphrase Dataset by AMR Back-Translation. In *Proceedings of the 61st Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL)*, 2023. (**Area Chair Award**)
3. Kuan-Hao Huang*, **Varun Iyer***, Anoop Kumar, Sriram Venkatapathy, Kai-Wei Chang, and Aram Galstyan. Unsupervised syntactically controlled paraphrase generation with abstract meaning representations. In *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2022 (EMNLP Findings)*, 2022.

EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant <i>University of Illinois Chicago</i> • Working with Professor Cornelia Caragea on zero-shot abstractive document summarization • Achieved SoTA zero-shot performance on abstractive summarization datasets on multiple metrics	Aug 2022 – Present <i>Chicago, IL</i>
Teaching Assistant <i>University of Illinois Chicago</i> • Led lab sections for discrete mathematics and C programming courses • Helped students better understand concepts in discrete math, functional/systems programming, and NLP	Jan 2023 – Present <i>Chicago, IL</i>
Applied Scientist Intern <i>Amazon</i> • Worked with Dr. Anoop Kumar on unsupervised paraphrase-based data augmentation • Leveraged Abstract Meaning Representations (AMRs) to generate syntactically diverse paraphrases • Achieved SoTA performance on unsupervised paraphrase generation task on several datasets	May 2021 – Dec 2021 <i>Remote</i>
Research Assistant <i>Johns Hopkins University</i> • Worked with Professor Benjamin van Durme on semantically grounded image classification • Augmented a ResNet architecture with geometric hierarchical embeddings for few-shot learning	May 2020 – Dec 2021 <i>Remote</i>
Undergraduate Researcher <i>University of Massachusetts Amherst</i> • Worked with Professor Andrew McCallum on fine-grained entity typing using PyTorch • Developed a stacked BiLSTM with embedding-based loss functions and hierarchical type constraints	Aug 2018 – May 2020 <i>Amherst, MA</i>

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: Python, Rust, C/C++, SQL
Frameworks: PyTorch, Transformers, vLLM, Kubernetes
Developer Tools: Git, Docker, GitLab CI/CD, tmux, VS Code, PyCharm, Helix
Libraries: Pandas, NumPy, Matplotlib, PyO3